



**SMLE MARK III WITH
WIRE-CUTTER ATTACHMENT**



**RIFLE NO 5 MARK I
"JUNGLE CARBINE"**

- 1879** James P. Lee develops a bolt-action, magazine-fed rifle; successful in its own right, this design attracts the interest of the British Army in 1888.
- 1895** The British Army adopts the Magazine, Lee-Enfield (MLE) rifle.
- 1907** The SMLE Mark III is introduced.
- 1914** British Army Sergeant Instructor Alfred Snoxall sets the world record for rapid fire, with 38 aimed rounds in a minute.

- 1915** Because the SMLE Mark III is quite complex to manufacture, the simpler SMLE Mark III is developed to fulfill the high rate of demand during World War I.
- 1939** The No. 4 Rifle is designed to be easy to mass-produce; its spike bayonet is known to soldiers as the "pig-sticker."

- 1943** A very quiet, suppressed version of the Lee-Enfield rifle, the De Lisle Carbine, is produced for British commando troops during World War II.
- 1944** The need for a short, lightweight rifle spurs the creation of the Rifle No. 5 Mark I, known as the "Jungle Carbine."

the new-style rifling were combined with Lee's rapid-firing bolt action in 1895, the new Lee-Enfield rifle was born. Lee's cock-on-closing action, in which the forward thrust of the bolt cocks the action, was faster than that of the Mauser Model 1898, which cocked on opening. The Lee-Enfield design also placed the bolt handle over the trigger, near to the user's hand, again making it faster to operate. A detachable 10-round magazine kept the weapon supplied with ammunition. Military commanders were initially sceptical about the removable magazine—they feared that soldiers would lose this vital piece of equipment in the heat of battle, and some early Lee-Enfields had a length of thin chain to keep the magazine tethered to the gun. Subsequent versions had a charger, or "stripper clip," loading system that did away with the need for the detachable magazine, while allowing the operator to load and fire at speed. The rate of fire possible with Lee-Enfield rifles was impressive and surprised Britain's enemies in World War I. There are accounts of German troops attacked by fire from Lee-Enfields mistaking this for machine-gun fire. This was borne out in target shooting, when skilled marksmen could hit a target at 300 yards (270m) more than 30 times a minute, and even inexperienced soldiers could achieve a rapid rate of fire.

VERSATILITY AND USE

The original Lee-Enfields were impressive, but many wanted a more accurate weapon that was also lighter. The manufacturers at Enfield responded with shorter and lighter models offering charger-loading and improved sights. The Army designated these firearms Rifle, Short, Magazine, Lee-Enfield (SMLE rifle for short). The SMLE Mark III,



▲ MODERN CONFLICTS

An Afghan soldier holds a 1902 Lee-Enfield rifle found during a joint US and Afghan Army raid in 2002 in Kunar province, Afghanistan.

introduced in 1907 and used throughout World War I, was the best-known of them. The way these Lee-Enfields combined a user-friendly layout with the ability to fire rapidly piqued the interest of many users, and the guns spread around the British Empire and beyond. Users also realized that the basic design—and later models that were simpler and easier to manufacture—could be modified for a range of uses. Many were converted

to .22in caliber so that they could act as training rifles firing inexpensive ammunition. Others, with the addition of features such as cheek pieces and telescopic sights, became sniper rifles. Conversions to automatic or semiautomatic loading were also carried out. Both the versatility of the original rifles and the various conversions have helped to keep the Lee-Enfield popular globally. It is widely used by police forces, for hunting, and for target shooting, and Lee-Enfields (or copies of the weapons) are still found in combat. The history of the Lee-Enfield is one of the greatest success stories in the world of firearms.

"It was a rifle light and handy, accurate at short and at long ranges and... capable of a remarkable rate of fire."
